

Digital Tools | Test Centre

this segment is Sahara. The PCs featured here are the Acer Aspire E500, HCL Beanstalk 4958, HP Pavilion m7280in, and the Sahara R3.

Features

As we mentioned earlier, the choicest components went into the making of these Media Center PCs. The core component of a Media Center PC is the TV-Tuner card—but there was none in the Acer and HCL PCs! We asked the companies for the TV-Tuners. Acer was quick to respond by sending us the TV-Tuner. Although the Sahara R3 came with a TV-Tuner and a remote, they forgot to send an IR receiver, so the remote turned out to be of no use!

The HP Pavilion m7280in came with a Conexant CX23416 TV-Tuner, as did the Acer Aspire E500. The Sahara R3 featured an even more exotic ATi Rio 550 TV-Tuner. All these feature hardware MPEG encoders that offload the CPU and take it upon themselves to encode video to MPEG during video capture.

The functions of an MCPC call for high CPU power, and all these did come equipped with high-end



HCL Beanstalk 4958

CPUs. The first three were powered by the Intel Pentium 4 with HyperThreading Technology, while the Sahara R3 was powered by the AMD Athlon64 3500+, the most powerful processor in this test—which was also featured on the Krypton Voyager 9 in the previous category.

We witnessed many firsts in this category. For the first time in this entire shootout, we saw a SATA II drive—with the Acer E500. The HP m7280in had a 160 GB hard drive, which means ample space for capturing content and also for other functions such as time-shift.

Also, for the first, we saw a PC come with a LightScribe DVD-

What's So Special About Windows Media Center Edition 2005?

Almost every computer shipped these days has Windows XP installed as the default operating system. Windows XP has several different editions—five, to be precise. These are Windows XP Professional, Windows XP Home Edition, Windows XP Tablet Edition, Windows XP x64 and Windows XP Media Center Edition 2005.

Of these, Windows XP Media Center Edition 2005 is the one that most people generally do not know much about. Here's a brief explanation of what's in Media Center Edition 2005.

What needs to come across at the outset is that Windows XP Media Center Edition 2005 is heavily oriented towards the multimedia or entertainment aspect of using a PC. Media Center PCs aim to be the entertainment hub of a digital home, and Windows XP MCE aims to enable just that. The pretty interface is extremely user-friendly, and lets you do stuff at the touch of a button. And beneath this cool surface runs a robust and well-oiled NT kernel.

Networking support is very good in Windows XP MCE, as with Windows XP Pro. However, there's some stuff available in Windows XP MCE that is not available in the regular Windows XP:

DVD Recording: Windows XP MCE allows you to record DVDs in a format that is compatible with consumer DVD Players.

TV-Functionality: MCE supports dual TV-Tuners, which means you can record programmes using one tuner while watching TV using the other. This includes both cable and satellite transmissions.

Media Center Extenders: These are networking devices that let you connect your Media Center box to other devices, such as a display, over a wired or wireless network. This gives you with the ability to do things like watch HDTV even if your MCPC is in another room.

My Videos: This offers an alternate view of your 'My Videos' folder in Windows XP, organising files and folders by date or by name, and displaying a thumbnail image for each clip. My Videos supports common video types including standard .avi, .mpg, and .wmv files.

The Remote Control: This piece of hardware is standard with Windows XP MCE. You can do just about everything on MCPC using the remote without once having to get up from your couch.

Scoreboard

BRAND

Features

CPU

Brand And Model
Clock Speed (GHz)
HDD Interface / Size (GB) / rpm
ODD Type
RAM Amount (MB) / Type / Speed (MHz)
Graphics Processor
Motherboard
Chipset
CPU Interface
PCIe / AGP slot
Keyboard Shortcut Keys (Y/N) / Ergonomics (So5)
Mouse Interface, Technology
Monitor Type / Size (Diagonal Inches)
Number of 5.25-inch bays
SMPS Power rating (W)
Front Connectors

Modem/Speakers Type

LAN Type

Quality of Buttons: Keyboard / Mouse / Cabinet (So5)
Number of Memory / PCI / Graphics slots

Package Contents

Operating System CD
Anti-Virus Package
Games / Educational Software / Other Software

Recovery / Driver CD

Miscellaneous (Headphones, Web cams, Gamepad, etc.)

Number Of Years Of Warranty

Performance

SiSoft Sandra 2005

CPU Dhrystones / Whetstones
CPU Multimedia (integer iter per sec / FP iter per sec)

Hard Disk Drive

Drive Index (MBps) / Access Time (ms)
Sequential / Random Read (MBps)
Sequential / Random Write (MBps)
Memory ALU to RAM / FPU to RAM (MBps)

Nero CD-DVD Speed

Average Read Speed (x) / Access Time (ms)

Gaming

Call of Duty 800 x 600 / 1024 x 768 (fps)
Far Cry 640 x 480 / 1024 x 768 (fps)

Business Winstone 2004

PCMark04 Marks

CPU / Memory
Graphics / HDD
Audio Encoding (DBPowerAmp) (sec)
Video Encoding (Dr. Divx) (sec)

Monitor DisplayMate Test

Horizontal / Vertical Bar Resolution (So5)
Fine Focus / Fine Res. / Diagonal Res. Matrix (So5)
Speakers Special Audio / Movie Files Test (So5)

Price (Rupees)

Price Index

Overall Score (Out Of 100)